reverence, having seen other, blazing horizons and guessed at many seductive truths.

After the Mazhar of 1579, once Akbar began to free himself from the need to be defined by a narrow Islamic identity, he began the complex and complicated process of creating a new identity for himself that reflected the diverse people and faiths of the court and the country. Among the nobility alone, for example, 17 per cent were Irani and another 15 per cent were Hindu. But before he could do that he had one last great challenge to face from someone who represented the old values and purely Timurid charisma —Mirza Hakim. In the next few years, having responded to the gauntlet laid down by that brother, Akbar would invite thinkers and scholars from across the empire and beyond the seas to Fatehpur Sikri and would assess the truth of their various beliefs.

As he evolved, another previously sacrosanct authority Akbar had finally outgrown were the duo of Abd un-Nabi and Abdullah Sultanpuri. ‘When two people clash together,’ was Badauni’s bitter assessment, referring to their constant bickering, ‘they fall together.’ Despite their great reluctance and shrill protests, Akbar sent them away to Mecca, with orders never to return to Hindustan. While the two mullahs were perforce being coaxed to depart to Surat and onward to the Holy Lands, three theologians of a different faith were heading in the opposite direction, from Goa to Fatehpur Sikri, carrying the relics of long-dead saints and dreams of martyrdom in their hearts.

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*Traditional Islamic medicine developed and refined after studying the systems of the ancient Greek physicians. Largely spread through the efforts of the tenth-century Muslim physician and scholar, Ibn Sina, more popularly known as Avicenna.

†House of the Deaf.

*The other three were Ghazi Khan, Qazi Jaladuddin Multani, and Sadri Jahan Mufti.

*Which could be understood either as ‘God is Great’ or ‘Akbar is God!’